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House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23352233; Fax: 23327330 ● 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai,
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● 2C, 'Suryarath Bldg', 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchwati, Office C-9, Road, Ahmedabad-380006;
Phone: 26560393, 26560929; Fax: 26565293

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Last week, when my wife, who knows as much about cricket as I know about make-up, started discussing the game with me, I knew Twenty20 had broken a new barrier. Like everyone else, I was hooked to the coverage of the Twenty20 World Cup. The fact that India won the trophy was an unexpected bonus but it was the exciting new format of the game that really caught the imagination. Not only is it action-packed, but it takes almost the same time to see an entire match as it would to watch a Bollywood movie. The event in South Africa even seemed scripted by Bollywood. India the underdogs brushing aside fancied opponents to meet—and beat—Pakistan in a pulsating final. I know there are purists who will scoff at what has been described as “hit and jiggle” cricket but a majority have become converts. They had also mocked the 50-over version when it was introduced and look at how that has changed the game.

After last week's history-making inauguration, Twenty20, with all its music, glitz and fireworks, on and off the field, is clearly here to stay. In India, television viewership ratings for the World Twenty20 skyrocketed elbowing out most popular shows. The economics of Twenty20 cricket clearly means that it has an assured future, more so with the Indian Cricket Board soon to introduce its own league in that format.



Our July 1983 cover

Deputy Editor Sharda Ugra, who was in South Africa to cover the event, spoke to a range of cricketers, past and present coaches and administrators, to analyse the impact that Twenty20 will have on the future of international cricket. They include ICC boss Malcolm Speed and the game's acknowledged master strategist, Australian coach John Buchanan, among others. We also spoke to sponsors and media planners to assess the future of the new format.

For Indian cricket, the signs are equally positive. This is the first big international trophy since the World Cup victory in 1983 and has been achieved by a bunch of youngsters. Captain Mahendra Singh Dhoni is 26 while the stars of the team are all in their early or mid-20s. More significant, these were mostly small town boys with fire in their bellies and the desire to win. The shift broadens the talent base and augurs well for Indian cricket only if the omnipresent politicians can keep their sticky fingers out of it. That they hadn't, was evident at the cricketers' homecoming at Mumbai's Wankhede Stadium where politicians hogged the limelight.

Whatever happens in the forthcoming series of India against Australia and Pakistan, I believe the game of cricket has changed forever. The freewheeling stroke play of the batsmen and the accuracy of the bowlers is bound to spill over to ODIs. New nations will enter the fray in the years to come. These are exciting times for cricket and we all have a lot to look forward to.

(Aroon Purie)